

A Useful Framework for Understanding Black Associations in pre Civil War Philadelphia

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Article Text

Students of the Black population of Philadelphia before the Civil War will encounter a wide variety of types of organizations.

As we have dug into the details of minute books and conference agendas, we've begun to intuit a *classification* of associations.

DuBois actually turned us on to the idea of making these classifications highly visual. In his 1907 *Economic Cooperation Among Negroes*, he provided a visual framework.

Here, Du Bois makes it easy to see how all different kinds of organizations and movements arose from, and influenced one another over the centuries.

For example, this visual argues that cultural aspects of Obeah worship influenced beneficial societies. Then, beneficial societies formed the necessary discipline and organization needed to launch a host of other organizations and associations.

With Du Bois as our inspiration, and hearing from so many people that it's a little hard to keep track of all the organizations and associations in antebellum Philadelphia, we have tried to emulate the good works of our ancestor.

Unlike Du Bois we are sticking to only 80 years (not 400 lol).

Check out our [ArcGis Storymap](#) that explains all the through-lines in detail.

This is a living document and we welcome updates and comments. We will turn on comments on this blog and incorporate ideas as they emerge.

Images

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